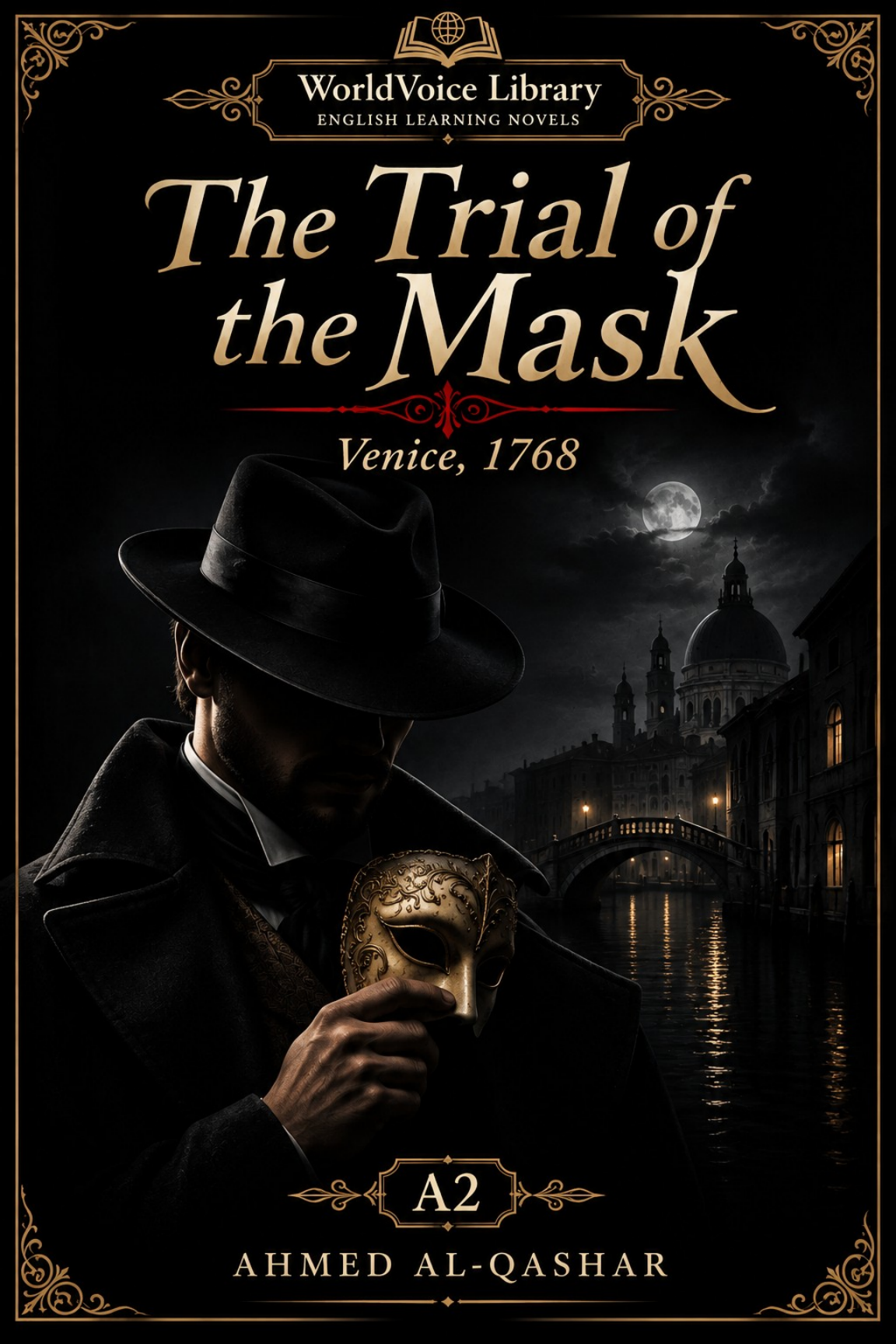
WorldVoice Library

ENGLISH LEARNING NOVELS

The Trial of the Mask

Venice, 1768



A2

AHMED AL-QASHAR

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The Trial of the Mask

Venice, 1768

A2 · ELEMENTARY

Ahmed Al-Qashar

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Story, learning activities, glossary, and book design prepared for WorldVoice Library. The narrative and characters are fictional. Historical locations and customs provide the setting.

The front-cover artwork was selected and approved for this edition. The interior chapter ornaments and scene illustrations are drawn as vector artwork in the book.

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A reading note

This novel uses clear A2-level English with short scenes, natural dialogue, and carefully repeated key words. Some historical and legal terms are explained in the glossary. Read the story first, then return to the exercises.

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Story Introduction

Venice, 1768. The city is full of music, dark canals, and white masks. During a winter celebration, a powerful merchant is found dead inside his palace. A young mask maker is accused of killing him.

His sister, Sofia, does not have money or important friends. But she knows how to ask questions, and she believes the smallest detail can change a life. With help from an unexpected ally, she searches for the truth before her brother loses his freedom.

The dead merchant was not innocent. For years, his business caused pain to other families. Just before his death, he decided to admit his mistakes and reveal dishonest payments. Someone wanted to stop him.

In a city where everyone wears a mask, who can the judges trust?

THE THEMES OF THIS STORY

- Truth and fair judgment
- Family, loyalty, and courage
- Regret, responsibility, and second chances

The People in This Story

Sofia Moretti

A young dressmaker. She searches for evidence to clear her brother's name.

Luca Moretti

A twenty-five-year-old mask maker accused of murder.

Giacomo Ferretti

A rich merchant who decides too late to correct old wrongs.

Pietro Valli

The palace manager who controls the business accounts and many doors.

Elisabetta Ferretti

Giacomo's daughter. She wants justice for her father, but also wants the truth.

Marta

A kitchen worker who is afraid to lose her job.

Paolo Conti

A gondolier who sees more than he first wishes to say.

Lorenzo Bellini

Giacomo's former business partner.

Signor Rinaldi

A city official who collects statements and examines evidence.

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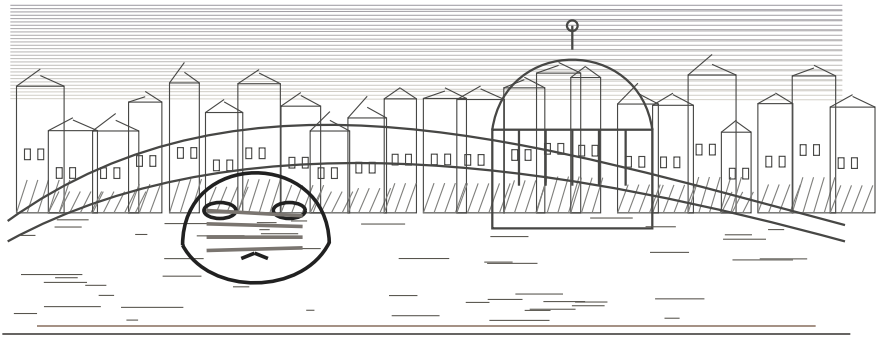
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After the story: A2 Vocabulary Glossary · Reading Comprehension · Language Practice · Writing & Discussion · Answer Key.

CHAPTER 1

The Night of Masks



On a cold evening in February 1768, Venice looked like a city made of stars. Small lights shone in the windows above the canals. Music came from an open door, and boats moved slowly over the black water. People crossed the narrow bridges in dark coats and fine shoes. Many wore white masks. For one night, a rich man and a poor man could hide behind the same face.

Luca Moretti did not enjoy such nights. He made masks, but he did not like wearing them. He was twenty-five, with dark hair and careful hands. His father had taught him to make strong masks from cloth, paper, and white paint. Since his father's death, Luca had worked in the small family shop near a quiet canal.

That evening he stood outside the great home of Signor Giacomo Ferretti. The palace had tall windows, stone steps, and two doors. One door faced the street. The other opened onto the water. Music flowed through both. Luca carried a wooden box with six white masks inside.

"You are late," said Pietro Valli, the palace manager, when he opened the door.

"I was told to come after sunset," Luca answered. "These are the last six masks. The others arrived yesterday."

Pietro wore a brown coat and carried a ring of keys. His eyes moved quickly from Luca's face to his box. "Put them in the small room beside the kitchen. And please stay out of the main hall."

"I need to speak to Signor Ferretti. He still owes my family money."

"Not tonight," Pietro said. "He has important guests."

Luca went through the servants' passage. The smell of warm bread made him hungry. A young kitchen worker named Marta stood near a table, trying to tie a broken ribbon on a servant's white mask.

"Can you repair this?" she asked. "I have no time to make another."

"Of course," Luca said. He put his box down. His fingers moved quickly. "Two minutes."

"The master has been angry all day," Marta whispered. "He argued with Pietro after breakfast. Then he asked for his old business accounts."

"That sounds like their problem," said Luca. He gave her back the mask. "There. It will hold."

In the great hall, the musicians began a faster dance. Luca walked toward the doorway and saw Ferretti speaking to his daughter, Elisabetta. She wore a pale blue dress, but no mask. Her father looked tired. He was a large man with silver hair. Years of trade had made him wealthy, and people said he could change a man's future with a single word.

"Signor Ferretti," Luca called. "I must speak with you."

Several guests turned. Pietro came forward, but Ferretti raised a hand.

"Let him speak."

"My father worked on your boats," Luca said. "After the accident at the old warehouse, you promised to pay the workers. My mother is still waiting."

Ferretti's face became pale. "Come tomorrow, Luca. We will talk."

"That is what you said last month."

"I know," Ferretti answered. For a moment, his voice sounded different. "I am going to make things right. But not in this hall."

Luca did not believe him. "Words are easy for a rich man," he said. Then he walked away. A few people laughed softly. Someone whispered that the young mask maker was brave. Others said he was foolish.

Pietro followed Luca to the servants' passage. "You have made a mistake," he said. "Go home before you make another."

"I came to collect a payment, not to make trouble."

"Then leave the box and go."

As Luca turned, he noticed a white mask on a chair by the passage door. It looked like one of his masks, but the inside had a dark green ribbon. He had not used green ribbon for Ferretti's order. Before he could ask about it, Pietro moved the chair into a small room and shut the door.

A bell rang from a distant church. The guests continued dancing. Luca returned to the kitchen, where Marta had broken a wooden shelf

and needed help. He took off his dark cape and laid it over the back of a chair. Then he held the shelf while Marta found a nail and a hammer.

Above them, a door closed with a hard sound. Someone ran across the stone floor. Marta looked up.

"Who is walking in the private rooms?" she asked.

"I don't know," Luca said. He reached for another nail.

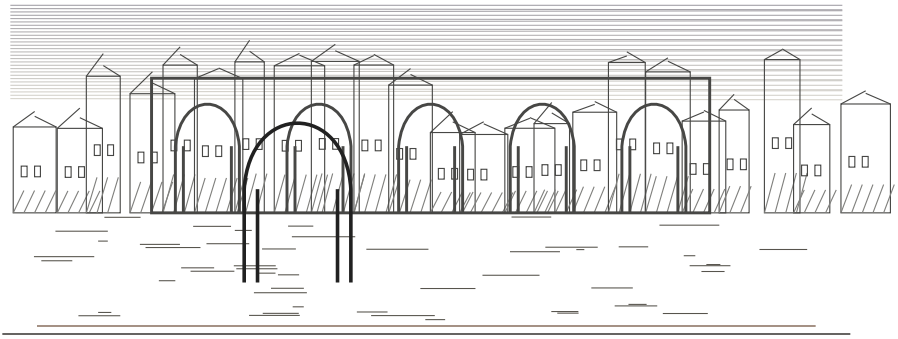
A few minutes later, a terrible cry came from the upper passage. The music stopped. Guests crowded near the stairs. Pietro appeared at the top, his face white.

"Signor Ferretti is dead," he said.

Luca stood still, the hammer in his hand. He had been angry with the man, but he had not wanted him dead. At that moment he did not know that the whole city would soon look at him as a murderer.

CHAPTER 2

A Man Accused



The palace was silent except for the wind against the windows. Men from the city guard came through the front door. They asked guests to remain in the hall while they questioned the servants. A serious-looking official examined the small room where Ferretti had been found. There was a dark mark on the floor and a chair lay on its side. No one wanted to look for long.

Luca sat beside Marta in the kitchen. His hands shook. He thought of his mother waiting for him at home. She would hear the news, and she would remember how loudly he had spoken to the dead man.

Pietro entered with two guards. He was carrying Luca's dark cape.

"Is this yours?" the official asked.

"Yes," Luca said. "I left it on a chair."

"One of the guests saw a man in this cape near Signor Ferretti's private room."

"Many people have dark capes tonight."

The official held up a white mask. A small red mark could be seen near its edge. "And this was found outside the room. Do you know it?"

Luca looked closely. "It came from my workshop, perhaps. I made many masks for the party."

"Did you argue with Signor Ferretti?"

"Yes. In front of everyone."

"Did you threaten him?"

"No. I asked for money that my family was promised."

"And where were you when the church bell rang?"

"In the kitchen. I was repairing a shelf with Marta."

The official turned to the young woman. Her lips were white. "Is that true?"

Marta looked past him to Pietro. She remembered the manager's words that morning: Workers who speak too much do not stay here long. Her family needed her wages.

"I remember Luca coming into the kitchen," she said quietly. "I don't remember the exact time."

Luca stared at her. She had stood beside him. She had given him the hammer. But now she would not meet his eyes.

The official asked Luca to stand. "You will come with us. There are more questions."

Outside, the rain had begun. A small crowd waited by the steps. One man shouted, "He killed Ferretti!" A woman asked if it was true. Luca said nothing. A guard led him into a covered boat. As it moved away, he

saw a figure at an upper window. It was Elisabetta, the dead man's daughter. Her face showed no anger, only shock.

At the Moretti workshop, Sofia was waiting with her mother when a neighbor brought the news. Sofia was Luca's younger sister, twenty-three, with dark eyes and the same careful hands as her brother. She made clothes for a living and knew every street between the market and their home.

"It cannot be Luca," their mother said. "He was bringing masks to the palace."

"I know," Sofia answered. But she remembered Luca's anger during the last week. He had said he would go to Ferretti's home and make the man listen. Those words frightened her now.

At sunrise she went to the office where Luca was being held. The guard would allow only a short visit. They sat across a narrow table, with another guard by the door.

"Tell me everything," Sofia said.

"I argued with Ferretti," Luca answered. "I should not have done it in front of his guests. But I did not hurt him. I was in the kitchen with Marta when he died."

"Then Marta can tell the officials."

"She was afraid. Pietro stood behind the guard. She said she did not know the time."

Sofia touched the table. "Why would Pietro want her to be afraid?"

"He controls all the servants," Luca said. "And there was another strange thing. One of my masks had a green ribbon inside. I did not put it there."

"Did you tell the official?"

"I tried. He said it was not important."

Sofia looked at her brother. "You must tell the truth, even when it makes you look foolish. Did you hide anything?"

Luca took a long breath. "I told Ferretti that he would pay for what happened to Father. It sounded like a threat. I was angry. But I meant that I would tell the city about the unpaid wages."

Sofia believed him, yet she did not smile. She knew belief was not enough. The officials needed reasons. They needed facts.

"I will find out who wore that mask," she said.

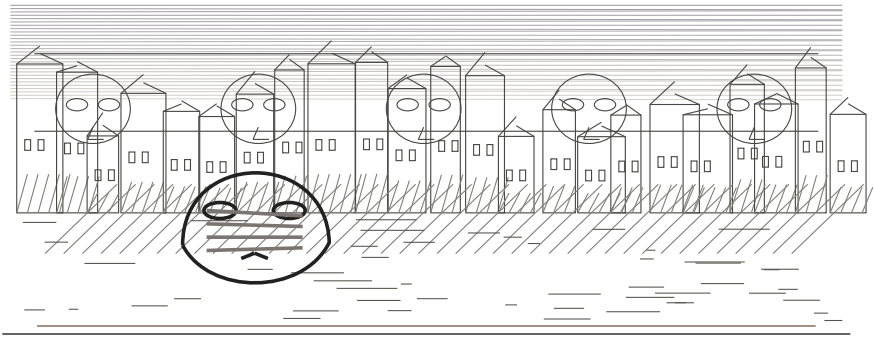
"Be careful, Sofia. This is not our street. These people can close doors in our faces."

She stood. "Then I will find another door."

When she returned to the shop, she saw a man in a fine black coat standing across the canal. He appeared to be watching the windows. As soon as he noticed her, he turned and walked away.

CHAPTER 3

The Mask Maker's Mark



Sofia locked the workshop door and placed three unfinished masks on the table. The morning light came through a small square window. She remembered her father's old rule: A good maker leaves a mark that only another maker will see.

Luca made each mask by hand. Small differences were natural. The masks for Ferretti's ball were white with black ribbons. Along the inside edge he had sewn two short stitches with grey thread. These were his mark. He also wrote the number of each order in a book that he kept beside the window.

Sofia opened the book. Ferretti had ordered twenty-four masks two weeks earlier and six more on the day of the ball. The order listed only black ribbons. No green ones.

There was a knock at the door. A tall man with a narrow face stood outside. "My name is Lorenzo Bellini," he said. "I was a business partner of Signor Ferretti. May I come in?"

Sofia hesitated. "Why do you want to speak to me?"

"Your brother is in trouble. I believe he has been treated unfairly."

Lorenzo sat beside the cold stove. His hands were clean, and his coat cost more than Sofia earned in several months. "Ferretti and I worked together many years ago," he said. "Then we argued about money. I left the company."

"Did you hate him?" Sofia asked.

The man looked surprised. "I was angry with him. That is not the same thing."

"Why are you here?"

"Last week Giacomo asked me to come back and look at some business accounts. He said that workers had lost money because of old decisions. He wanted to pay them. I thought he was trying to change."

"Did you see the accounts?"

"Not yet. We planned to meet after the ball."

Sofia thought of her father, who had been hurt when a wooden platform fell at one of Ferretti's warehouses. He died the following winter after months of poor health. She could not know how much the accident had changed him. She only knew that the family had needed money and the money had never arrived.

"Why would Ferretti suddenly care?" she asked.

"Another worker died in an accident at the warehouse last autumn," Lorenzo said. "I think Giacomo finally understood what his choices had done."

"Can you tell this to the officials?"

"I can tell them what I know. But I do not know who killed him."

After Lorenzo left, Sofia brought the order book close to the light. On the last page was a small note in Luca's writing: 'Manager asked about an extra ribbon. Told him I had none.' The date was three days before the ball.

She went to the street where small shops sold thread, cloth, and buttons. A woman named Teresa knew her family well. Teresa sold dark green silk ribbon for special masks.

"Did anyone from the Ferretti house buy green ribbon?" Sofia asked.

"Several people buy it," Teresa answered. "Why?"

"I am trying to help Luca."

Teresa's face became serious. "A servant from the palace came on Monday. He bought a short piece, not enough for clothes. He said it was for a hat."

"What did he look like?"

"He was young, with fair hair. I did not know his name. But he paid with a coin from a small leather purse with a silver button."

Sofia knew that such a description was not proof. The servant could have been buying ribbon for anyone. Still, it connected the extra ribbon to the palace, not to Luca's order.

That afternoon Sofia returned to Ferretti's house. The front door was closed. A maid told her that no visitors were welcome. Sofia was turning away when Elisabetta appeared on the stairs.

"You are the mask maker's sister," Elisabetta said. Her face was tired. "Why have you come?"

"I want to ask about a mask with green ribbon. I think somebody used it to make Luca look guilty."

"My father is dead," Elisabetta answered sharply. "And you are asking about a ribbon."

"Because my brother is alive," Sofia said. "He may lose his future for something he did not do."

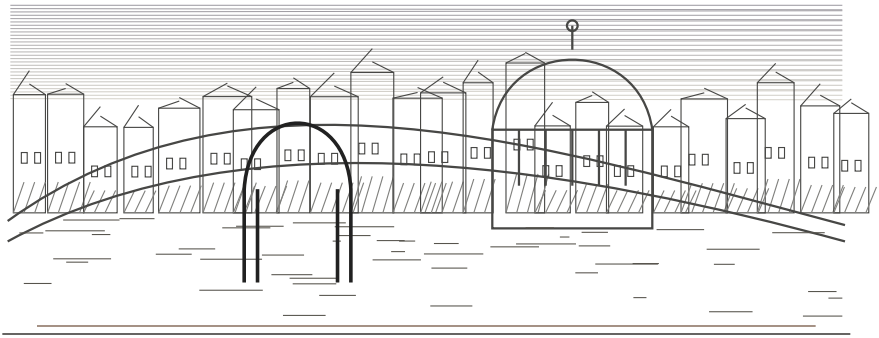
For a moment the two women stood in silence. Then Elisabetta looked back toward the hall. "Come tomorrow morning," she said. "Before Pietro arrives. I will ask the servants to show you the masks that remain."

"Thank you."

"I have not promised to help you," Elisabetta said. "I have promised to look. Those are different things."

CHAPTER 4

The Door by the Water



The next morning was grey and cold. Sofia came to the palace before the market opened. Elisabetta met her at a small side entrance. Without a word, she led her through a long passage to the hall where the guests had danced.

The music had gone. A few chairs stood along the walls. Masks and decorations had been collected in two wooden boxes. Sofia examined them slowly. Many were dirty or bent. She counted twenty-nine, then counted again. One mask was missing from Luca's order of thirty.

"Could somebody have taken it home?" Elisabetta asked.

"Yes. But Luca told me the officials found one near your father's room. That may be the missing one."

Elisabetta picked up a white mask. "I wore one for a short time," she said. "They all look alike to me."

"That is the trouble," Sofia answered.

They walked toward the servants' passage. The kitchen was busy, but Marta stopped when she saw them. Sofia asked if they could speak privately. Elisabetta went with them to a small room beside the bread oven.

"My brother says you saw him repairing a shelf," Sofia began.

Marta nodded. "Yes."

"Then why did you tell the officials you did not know the time?"

Marta looked down at her hands. "Because I did not. There were several bells that night. The church bell, the dinner bell, and the small bell in the kitchen. I was frightened. Pietro said I must not guess."

"You do not need to guess," Elisabetta said quietly. "Tell us what you remember."

Marta closed her eyes. "The cook was taking bread from the oven. I dropped the old shelf against a table. Luca came to help. The church bells began while he held the wood. He laughed because the noise made me jump. After that, someone ran upstairs."

"Was Luca still with you when the running began?" Sofia asked.

"Yes. He had the hammer in his hand."

Sofia felt hope for the first time. It was only one person's memory, but it was clear. "Will you tell the official that?"

Marta looked at Elisabetta. "If I speak, Pietro may send me away. I send money to my mother."

Elisabetta pressed her lips together. "Pietro cannot dismiss you for telling the truth. The house is mine to manage now, at least until the accounts are settled. I will stand beside you."

The three women went to the passage by the water door. A narrow stair led down to a small landing where boats delivered food and goods. The lower step was wet. A rope hung from an iron ring in the wall.

"There was a boat here on the night of the ball," Marta said. "I heard the wood knock against the stone."

"Who uses this door?" Sofia asked.

"Pietro, most often. He checks the deliveries. A guard has a key too."

A voice behind them answered, "And servants, when they are told to open it."

Pietro stood at the top of the stairs. Elisabetta moved between him and Sofia.

"We are looking at the service entrance," she said.

"A strange place for a lady to visit," Pietro replied. "The floor is dirty and the air is cold."

"It is my father's house," Elisabetta answered. "I may visit every room."

Pietro's face remained calm, but his hand closed around his keys. Sofia noticed a small silver button on the leather purse at his belt. It was like the one Teresa had described at the ribbon shop.

"Who bought the green ribbon for the masks?" Sofia asked suddenly.

"I do not know what you mean," Pietro said.

"Someone from this house bought it."

"We bought many things for the ball. Ask the servants." He turned to Elisabetta. "Signor Bellini has sent another request to see the business accounts. Your father did not trust that man."

"My father invited Lorenzo here last week," Elisabetta said.

Pietro stopped for only a moment. "Then your father changed his mind."

Sofia watched him walk away. She had not caught him in a lie. Not yet. But she was beginning to understand something important: every time she asked about a mask or a door, Pietro tried to make her speak about another person.

Later that morning she went to find Paolo Conti, a gondolier who had carried guests to the ball. Near the fish market, she found him repairing an old wooden seat in his boat.

"I remember you," Paolo said. "Your father often crossed the canal with me."

"Did you carry anyone away from Ferretti's water door on the night he died?"

Paolo put down his tool. "I carried guests from the front steps. The service door was not my business."

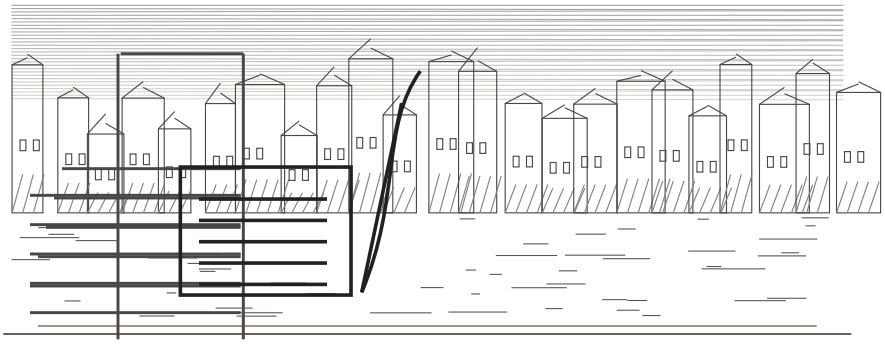
"Did you see a boat there?"

He looked toward the canal. "There are many boats in Venice, Sofia. Some are better left alone."

She knew then that Paolo had seen something. And she knew he was afraid to tell her.

CHAPTER 5

The Price of Silence



By midday the sky had cleared, but Sofia's thoughts remained dark. Marta would tell the truth if Elisabetta stood with her. Paolo knew something about the water door but would not speak. Luca was still being held, and the city was full of stories about his anger and the dead merchant's broken promises.

Sofia went to the small square near the market. A group of workers stood outside a baker's shop, talking about Ferretti's business. One old man said the merchant had always been greedy. Another said he had paid fair prices until Pietro took charge of the accounts. They all spoke as if they knew the whole truth, but each knew only a piece.

"My brother may be punished because of such stories," Sofia told them. "If you know a fact, say it. If you only heard a rumor, do not make it larger."

The men fell silent. A worker named Angelo stepped forward. "I was at the old warehouse when the platform fell," he said. "Your father was

one of the injured men. Pietro told us the repair money had already been spent. I believed him then. I am not so sure now."

"Why not?"

"Last month Giacomo came to the warehouse and looked at the broken roof. He asked me what had happened. He looked surprised when I told him the old repairs had never been done."

"Would you tell that to the officials?"

"Yes," Angelo answered. "My wife was hurt in another accident. I should have spoken years ago."

That evening Sofia visited her brother again. Luca had slept badly. He asked about their mother before he asked about his own future.

"She eats and sleeps," Sofia said. "She wants you home."

"And what have you found?"

Sofia told him about the green ribbon, the water door, and Marta's memory. Then she asked about his missing cape. Luca frowned.

"Pietro took it from the kitchen chair for a short time," he said. "He told me a guest had dropped wine on his own cloak and needed something dark to wear. I thought he wanted to borrow mine. I asked for it back, but he said he would return it after the ball."

"Why did you not tell the official?"

"I did. I said Pietro moved it. The official was busy asking why I had argued with Ferretti."

"Then say it again. Clearly."

"Sofia, there is something else." Luca lowered his voice. "I did not go to the ball only for money. I wanted to tell Ferretti that Father kept a

small wooden box of unpaid bills. I thought those bills might help the other workers."

"Where is the box?"

"At home, in the cupboard under the stairs. I had forgotten it until this week."

Sofia was angry. "You should have told me!"

"I did not think it mattered until now."

"Everything matters now," she said. Then she saw how tired he was. "I am sorry. I will look."

At home, Sofia found the box. It contained simple papers: names, dates, payments due, and her father's careful marks. She could understand most of them. The same names appeared on lists she had seen at the warehouse. Her father had not kept a secret message; he had kept records because he was afraid people would forget the workers.

The next morning, Sofia carried the box to Lorenzo Bellini. He compared the bills with a copy of an old business record that he still owned.

"Look at this line," he said. "The company marked a payment for repairs three years ago. But your father wrote that no work was done."

"Could Giacomo have kept the money?" Sofia asked.

"Yes. Or someone could have taken it without his knowledge. He signed the final account, so he was responsible either way."

"And Pietro?"

"Pietro prepared the records. He has done that work for many years."

Lorenzo did not say Pietro was a murderer. Sofia respected that. A dishonest account could explain a reason for a crime. It could not show who had entered a room with a weapon.

When Sofia left, she saw Paolo standing beside his boat. He had waited for her.

"I heard you were asking questions," he said. "I will tell you one thing. On the night of the ball, a boat left the service door just after the bells. I did not see the passenger's face. But I saw the man who gave the boatman a coin. He was not wearing a mask."

"Who was he?" Sofia asked.

Paolo stared at the water. "I know him. And I know what happens to men who lose the favor of the powerful."

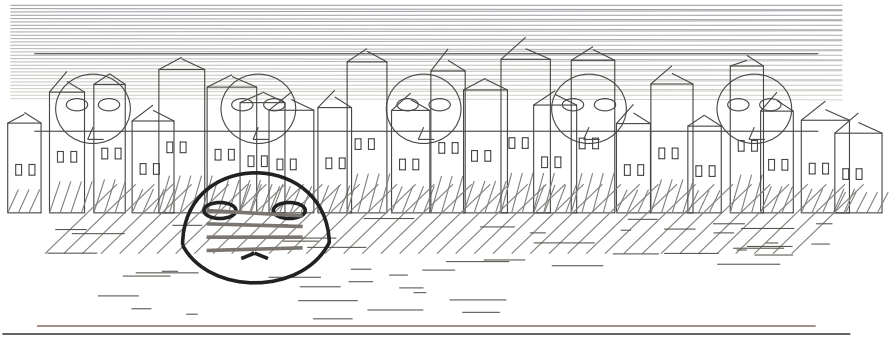
"Luca may lose his freedom," Sofia said. "Would you rather remain silent?"

Paolo closed his eyes. "Meet me tomorrow near the old bridge. I will decide what I can say."

That night a folded piece of paper was pushed under Sofia's door. It held only four words: Stop asking about Ferretti. She read it twice, then placed it on the table. There was no name and no proof of who had written it. But for the first time, she understood that someone was trying to frighten her away.

CHAPTER 6

Two White Masks



Sofia did not tell her mother about the warning. She knew it would only make her worry. Instead, she put the paper away and went to the mask workshop. A familiar place helped her think. She set two plain white masks on the table and asked herself what the officials really knew.

A guest had seen a man in a dark cape. A mask from Luca's workshop had been found near Ferretti's room. Luca had argued with Ferretti in public. None of these facts proved that Luca had entered the room when the merchant died.

Sofia examined the edge of each mask. One had a small grey mark sewn inside, and the other had a different mark. Luca always made two stitches, but he moved them a little on special orders. It was an old habit learned from their father.

The mask found at the palace was now with the officials. Sofia could not touch it. But she could show them the workshop order book and explain the different ribbons.

When she reached the old bridge, Paolo was waiting in his boat. He did not greet her warmly.

"I have a family," he said. "If I lose my place at the boats, my children will go hungry."

"I understand," Sofia replied. "My family has lived with the same fear."

"On the night of the ball I was resting near the service steps. I saw Pietro come out of the palace. His coat was open, and he was carrying a dark cape. He gave money to a young boatman who had come with a small boat. The young man left quickly."

"Did Pietro enter the boat?"

"No. He went back inside. I heard him use his keys."

"Did you see him go to Ferretti's room?"

"No. I would not say I did."

"Then tell the officials exactly what you saw. Nothing more."

Paolo looked at her. "That is what your father would have said. He was a good man."

At the palace, Elisabetta waited with Marta and an older cook named Renzo. The cook confirmed that Luca had been helping with the broken shelf as the church bells rang. Renzo remembered because he had just taken a round loaf from the oven and had burned one finger.

"I shouted at Luca for leaving the hammer near the bread," he said. "I remember it clearly."

"Will you tell the official?" Sofia asked.

"If the young woman has the courage," he answered, looking at Marta, "then I should have it too."

Elisabetta led Sofia to her father's writing room. The books stood neatly against the walls. His large desk held a pen, an empty glass, and a small account book with a broken cover.

"Pietro moved the other accounts yesterday," Elisabetta said. "He told me they were needed for the business. I asked him to wait, but he said everything was urgent."

"Does he have the right to move them?"

"He managed Father's work for years. I trusted him."

Sofia opened the book and found a page titled 'Warehouse Repairs'. The names of several workers appeared beneath it. One was her father's name. Another was Angelo's. The amounts promised to them were larger than anything they had received.

Elisabetta took the book. Her hands began to shake. "My father signed this. He knew."

"Perhaps he knew some of it," Sofia said. "Lorenzo said he asked to see the accounts before he died."

"He told me the same thing," Elisabetta whispered. "He said he wanted me to know the truth about the business. I was angry and said I would not listen. Now I cannot ask him why."

Sofia did not know what to say. A dead man could be both guilty of wrong choices and the victim of a terrible crime. His daughter had to carry both truths.

Elisabetta opened a drawer. "There is one more thing. Father asked Pietro for the key to the second account chest. Pietro said he had lost it. But I saw it on his ring yesterday. It has a small lion cut into the metal."

"Can you describe that to the officials?" Sofia asked.

"Yes," Elisabetta said. "Even if it makes me ashamed of this house."

Later, outside the palace, Sofia noticed a young servant walking quickly toward the market. It was the fair-haired man who carried Pietro's bags. He had the leather purse with the silver button.

"Excuse me," Sofia called. "Did you buy a green ribbon on Monday?"

The young man stopped. "Yes. For Signor Pietro. He told me he wanted to repair a mask himself."

"Did you see the mask?"

"I saw two white masks on his desk. One had a green ribbon inside. He said they were for a guest."

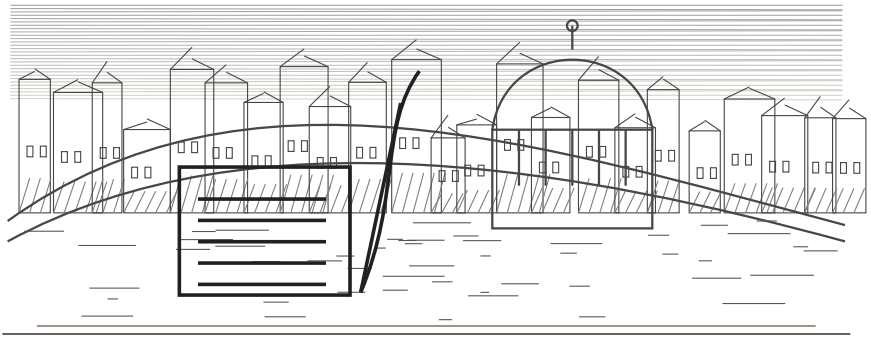
"Will you tell that to the official?"

The servant hesitated. Then he nodded. "I will tell what I saw. But I will not say more than that."

For the first time, Sofia had witnesses who could support one another. She still could not prove that Pietro had killed Ferretti. But the official story about Luca was no longer the only story.

CHAPTER 7

The Honest Account



The city official who had questioned Luca was named Signor Rinaldi. He worked for a magistrate and was responsible for collecting statements. When Sofia asked to see him, he did not look pleased. He had many cases and very little time.

"You have already told me that your brother is innocent," he said. "That is what every sister would say."

"I have not come only to say that," Sofia answered. She placed Luca's order book, her father's bills, and a list of witnesses on his desk. "I have come because some facts were missing."

Rinaldi opened the books. He read the names and dates carefully. When he saw the different kinds of thread beside Sofia's drawings of the masks, he asked her to explain them. He took notes as she spoke.

"You must understand," he said at last, "a mask with green ribbon is not proof of murder."

"I understand," Sofia answered. "And a white mask from my brother's shop is not proof of murder either."

Rinaldi looked up. "That is a fair answer."

The next two days were busy. Rinaldi spoke to Marta, Renzo, Paolo, and the young servant. Their stories were not exactly the same. They had stood in different places and had seen different things. But the accounts fit together: Luca had helped in the kitchen during the bells, Pietro had used the water door, and someone at the palace had changed a mask without Luca's help.

Rinaldi also questioned a junior clerk who worked for Pietro. The clerk admitted that Pietro had asked him to watch the Moretti workshop from across the canal. Later, he had pushed a warning under Sofia's door. The clerk said he had done it because he feared losing his job. Rinaldi wrote this in his report. It did not prove who had killed Giacomo, but at last Sofia knew why someone had been watching her.

Rinaldi also visited the warehouse. He examined the old repair records with Lorenzo and Angelo. The company had paid for work that the workers said was never done. More than one account had been changed. Giacomo had signed some records himself, but other amounts had been added afterward.

"Who made the changes?" Rinaldi asked Lorenzo.

"I cannot say from the writing alone," Lorenzo said. "But Pietro kept these accounts. He knows what each payment was for."

Rinaldi read the ledger, the large book of business payments, again. Then he returned to the palace and asked Pietro to show him the second account chest. Pietro answered that the key was missing.

"Your employer's daughter saw it on your ring," Rinaldi said.

"She may have seen another key."

"Then let us examine them."

Pietro gave him the ring slowly. There was a key with a small lion cut into the metal. It opened the chest. Inside were copies of payments and notes about repairs. They showed that money had gone to an account controlled by Pietro. Rinaldi did not accuse him of murder that day, but he ordered him not to leave the city while the inquiry continued.

That evening, Pietro went to the water door carrying a small bag. Paolo saw him from across the canal. The gondolier had agreed to help the officials watch the house, and he called to a guard nearby. Pietro stopped when he heard the guard's voice.

"I was going to visit a friend," he said.

"Then you may visit him tomorrow," the guard answered. "Tonight we have questions."

Pietro was brought before Rinaldi. He said he had handled the money badly but had never harmed Ferretti. He also said he had been in the main hall when Ferretti died.

"The cook says you came through the service passage just after the bells," Rinaldi replied.

"He is mistaken."

"The gondolier saw you at the water door."

"He wants to help the Moretti family. He is not a reliable witness."

"And the servant bought green ribbon for you."

"It was a small purchase. I repair my own things."

Rinaldi put down his pen. "Any one of these facts may have a simple answer. Together they need an explanation."

Pietro asked to speak with an advocate. Rinaldi agreed. The investigation would continue, and Pietro would have the chance to answer the accusations formally.

Sofia heard the news from Elisabetta. "Are they going to free Luca?" she asked.

"Not yet," Elisabetta replied. "They must review the earlier statements."

"Then I will wait," Sofia said. She was tired, but she had learned something important during those days. Finding the truth was not like opening a locked door with one key. It was more like crossing a canal on many small stones. Each had to be strong enough to carry her weight.

Before sunset, Lorenzo came to the Moretti home with a bag of food for Sofia's mother. He stood awkwardly in the doorway.

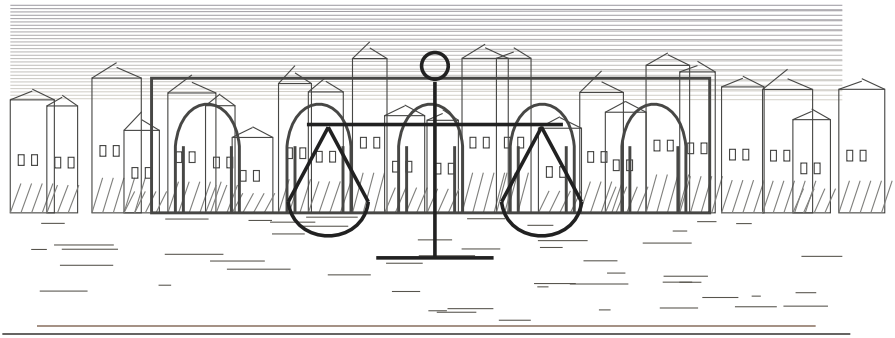
"I knew there were problems in the company years ago," he said. "I left instead of asking more questions. Perhaps I could have stopped some harm."

"Perhaps," Sofia answered. "But you can help the workers now."

"I will," Lorenzo said. And this time she believed he meant it.

CHAPTER 8

Before the Judges



The hearing took place in a high stone building not far from the center of Venice. It was not like the plays Sofia had seen at the small theater. There was no crowd shouting for one side, and no single man waiting to make a grand speech. Officials read statements, asked questions, and compared accounts. The work was slow and serious. For Luca, every hour felt longer than a day.

Sofia sat on a wooden bench beside her mother. Elisabetta sat several places away, her hands folded. Paolo waited by the door. Marta and Renzo had come together. Lorenzo stood near an official who carried the books.

Luca entered with a guard. He looked thinner than before, but when he saw Sofia, he managed a small smile. She nodded to him. She wanted to tell him that the truth was finally being heard, yet she knew the hearing could still go badly.

An official read the first report. It described Luca's argument with Giacomo and the white mask found near the private room. It also

described a witness who had seen a man in a dark cape entering the passage.

One of the judges asked, "Did the witness see the man's face?"

"No," the official answered. "The man wore a mask."

"Did the witness know the cape belonged to Luca?"

"He believed it did after he saw Luca later."

"Belief after the event is not the same as knowing at the time," the judge said. "Record that carefully."

Luca's advocate then asked for the new statements to be read. Marta stood and told the judges about the broken shelf, the bread, and the church bells. Her hands trembled, but she did not change her story. Renzo gave the same account from the other side of the kitchen. He remembered the hot bread and the hammer on the table.

"Could Luca have left the kitchen for a short time?" a judge asked.

"Not during the bells," Renzo said. "I was speaking to him."

"What about before or after?"

"I cannot speak for every minute," Renzo answered. "Only for the time I remember."

Sofia was proud of him. He had not tried to make his story stronger than it was. He had told the truth, including its limits.

Paolo spoke next. He said he had seen Pietro with a dark cape near the service door. He did not claim to have seen the murder. He described the boat and the sound of the manager's keys. Pietro's advocate asked how Paolo could be sure of the man's identity in the poor light.

"He was not wearing a mask when I saw him," Paolo replied. "I knew his face, and I had carried him in my boat before."

Then the judges examined the mask order. Sofia explained Luca's two grey stitches and the black ribbons used for the order. The young servant confirmed that he had bought green ribbon for Pietro and had seen two masks in the manager's room.

"So another person could have used a mask made in Luca's shop," a judge said.

"Yes," Sofia answered. "That is all I can say from these facts."

Finally, the books were placed before the judges. Lorenzo explained the old repair payments. Angelo described the broken platform and the repairs that had never happened. Elisabetta then stood. Her voice was quiet, but everyone could hear her.

"My father told me he was going to tell the truth about the business," she said. "He said we could not keep our house clean by hiding dirty work. I was angry with him. I thought he would make our family poor. I did not listen."

She looked across the room toward Luca. "I believed this young man killed my father because I knew he was angry. Now I know I was wrong to be so certain."

A judge asked if Giacomo had named the person he wanted to report. Elisabetta shook her head. "No. He only said the accounts would show what happened."

Pietro's turn came. He said that he had not left the hall near the time of the bells. But the records showed he had used the service door, and several witnesses placed him in the passage. His advocate argued that using a door and holding a cape were not crimes.

"That is true," the judge said. "But we must understand why your account of your movements has changed."

Pietro answered that he had been confused after his employer's death. He admitted that some business money had gone to his own account, but he said Ferretti had allowed it. Lorenzo pointed to dates that were written after Ferretti had begun reviewing the books. The judges examined them carefully.

Sofia felt her heart beat quickly. There was no dramatic confession. No one stood up and shouted the killer's name. Instead, a picture was forming, piece by piece, from ordinary facts. Pietro had a reason to fear Giacomo's new plans. He had the opportunity to take a mask and cape. And his own words did not agree with several other witnesses.

After a long pause, the senior judge spoke. "The evidence against Luca Moretti is not sufficient to keep him under this accusation. His public anger is not proof of murder. The investigation into Signor Pietro Valli must continue."

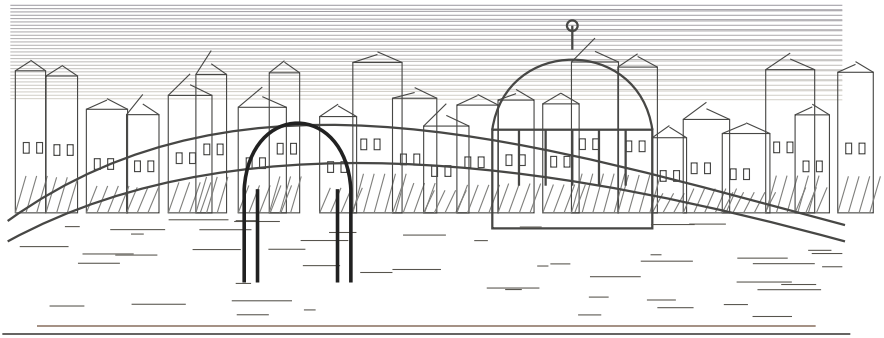
Luca closed his eyes. Sofia covered her mouth with one hand. The judge had not solved every question about the murder, but the first terrible mistake was being corrected.

As Luca was led from the room, he turned to Sofia. "You found another door," he whispered.

She smiled through her tears. "Several," she answered.

CHAPTER 9

The Face Behind the Mask



Luca was allowed to return home the following morning. The narrow workshop felt warmer than it had for weeks. His mother held him so tightly that he laughed and cried at the same time. Sofia made bread and soup, though she was too tired to eat much herself.

"I should never have shouted at Giacomo in front of his guests," Luca said when they sat together. "It made me look guilty."

"You had a right to ask for what was owed," Sofia answered. "But anger can hide the truth, just as a mask can."

"I was angry because I thought no one would listen if I spoke quietly."

"Then we must make them listen in a better way."

The officials continued their work. Pietro was questioned about the money, the masks, and his movements during the ball. He still said he had not killed Ferretti. But a fuller examination of the palace showed that he had ordered one mask to be changed after Luca delivered it. A

servant had found Luca's cape in Pietro's small office after the death, not in the kitchen where Luca had left it. The evidence did not depend on one person's memory alone.

Rinaldi called Sofia to his office once more. He explained that Pietro would face further proceedings over the business fraud and the killing. The final judgment would take time. Some questions had not yet been answered, and the court would continue to test the evidence.

"Will he be punished?" Sofia asked.

"The judges must decide that," Rinaldi said. "Your brother was freed because the evidence against him was weak and contradicted by other facts. We must be just as careful with the case against Pietro."

Sofia was surprised by the answer, but she understood it. The city had almost punished her brother for a crime he had not committed. It could not make the same mistake with another man, even one she now distrusted.

Elisabetta visited the Moretti shop three days later. She came without a servant and wore a plain grey cloak. She looked older than when Sofia had first met her at the palace.

"I wanted to thank you," she said. "You were kind to me, even when I believed your brother was guilty."

"I was not always kind," Sofia answered. "I was angry too."

Elisabetta studied the unfinished masks on the table. "My father made many bad choices. He was also my father. I loved him. I do not know how to feel both things at once."

"You do not have to decide today," Sofia said. "Both things can be true."

Elisabetta placed a small purse on the table. "Some money from the business is being held while the officials examine the accounts. But I can pay for the masks your brother made. This is money from my own household funds."

Luca counted the coins and wrote a receipt. He did not ask for more than the work was worth. When he handed it to her, he said, "Your father told me he wanted to make things right. I did not believe him. I wish I had listened."

"I wish I had listened too," Elisabetta replied.

In the weeks that followed, Lorenzo and a group of workers asked the business to review old payments. The records were difficult, and some money was still missing. No single meeting could repair the wrong done over many years. Yet the workers were finally being heard, and the Moretti family was not alone.

Spring came to Venice. Light returned to the canals, and people opened their shutters earlier each morning. The market was loud again. Luca made masks for travelers, actors, and children. Some were plain white; others carried blue flowers or bright red lines. He tried to make each one strong enough to last for many years.

One afternoon he found Sofia painting a small wooden sign for the shop. She had written: MORETTI MASKS — HONEST WORK, HONEST PRICE.

"Do you think anyone will notice?" he asked.

"The right people will," Sofia answered.

Luca smiled. He picked up a simple white mask and held it near his face. Through its two dark eyeholes he could see the familiar room: the worktable, the open window, and his sister standing in the sunlight.

For years, he had thought a mask was only something people wore to hide who they were. Now he knew it could also make people look again, ask better questions, and remember that a face was not the whole truth.

He placed the mask gently on its stand, then opened the shop door to the street. Outside, the city was busy with ordinary life. It was not a perfect city. But it was a city where a quiet voice, joined by other honest voices, could still be heard.

AFTER THE STORY

Read · Remember · Use

A2 Learning Companion

The next pages help you understand the story, build useful vocabulary, practise English grammar in context, and write your own short responses.

Do the activities in order. Write your answers in a notebook. You can check the reading and language answers at the end of the book.

Vocabulary Glossary

Sixty useful words from the story. Read the meaning and the example sentence.

accuse — to say that someone did something wrong
They accused Luca of the crime.

account — a written record of money received or spent
Pietro kept the business accounts.

admit — to say that something is true
He admitted that he was afraid.

advocate — a person who helps someone with a legal case
Luca spoke to his advocate.

argue — to speak angrily because you disagree
Luca argued with the merchant.

ashamed — feeling bad because of something wrong
She felt ashamed of the old lies.

believe — to think that something is true
Sofia believed her brother.

bell — a metal object that makes a ringing sound
The church bell rang at night.

borrow — to take something for a short time and return it
He borrowed Luca's dark cape.

brave — able to face fear or danger
Marta was brave enough to speak.

canal — a waterway made or used for boats
The boats moved along the canal.

cape — a loose piece of clothing worn over the shoulders
The man wore a dark cape.

chest — a strong box used to keep things
The accounts were in a wooden chest.

claim — to say that something is true
Pietro claimed he stayed in the hall.

collect — to bring things together
Rinaldi collected witness statements.

confess — to admit that you did something wrong
He wanted to confess his past mistakes.

correct — to make something right or accurate
The official corrected the report.

court — a place where legal decisions are made
Luca entered the court with a guard.

decision — a choice you make
Giacomo made a difficult decision.

deliver — to take something to a person or place
Luca delivered the masks to the palace.

deny — to say something is not true
Pietro denied the accusation.

detail — a small part of a larger thing
Sofia noticed a tiny detail.

evidence — facts that can help show what is true
The judges examined the evidence.

fair — treating people in a just and equal way
The judges wanted a fair decision.

favor — help or special kindness from someone
Paolo feared losing an important favor.

fear — the feeling of being afraid
Fear kept Marta silent.

freedom — the state of not being kept in prison
Luca hoped to regain his freedom.

gondola — a long, narrow boat used in Venice
Paolo worked on a gondola.

guilty — responsible for doing something wrong
Luca was not guilty of murder.

honest — truthful; not cheating
The shop promised honest work.

innocent — not responsible for a crime
Sofia believed Luca was innocent.

investigate — to examine facts to find out the truth
The officials investigated the murder.

judge — an official who makes legal decisions
A judge asked a careful question.

key — a metal object used to open a lock
Pietro carried a ring of keys.

ledger — a book in which business money is recorded
The ledger showed the repair payments.

manager — a person who controls work in a place
Pietro was the palace manager.

mask — a covering worn over the face
Guests wore white masks at the ball.

merchant — a person who buys and sells goods
Giacomo was a rich merchant.

murder — the crime of killing a person on purpose
The officials investigated the murder.

official — a person with authority in an organization
The official read the statements.

owe — to need to pay money to someone
The merchant owed money to workers.

passage — a narrow way between rooms
The passage led to the kitchen.

payment — money given for work or goods
The workers waited for their payments.

promise — to say you will do something
Giacomo promised to repay the families.

punish — to make someone suffer for doing wrong
The city must not punish an innocent man.

receipt — a written record showing payment
Luca wrote a receipt for the money.

regret — to feel sorry about a past choice
Giacomo began to regret his actions.

repair — to fix something broken
Luca helped repair the shelf.

report — to tell someone in authority about a problem
She reported the new evidence.

responsible — having a duty or being the cause of something
Giacomo was responsible for the accounts.

ribbon — a thin strip of cloth
The mask had a green ribbon inside.

rumor — a story people tell that may not be true
The market was full of rumors.

servant — a person paid to work in another person's home
Marta was a servant in the palace.

statement — a spoken or written account of what happened
The official read Marta's statement.

suspect — a person thought to have done something wrong
Luca was the first suspect.

threat — words or actions that suggest harm
Luca's angry words sounded like a threat.

trust — to believe that someone is honest or reliable
Elisabetta had trusted Pietro.

warehouse — a large building used to store goods
The old warehouse needed repairs.

witness — a person who sees an event happen
Paolo was an important witness.

wrong — not right or fair
The business had done wrong to its workers.

Reading Comprehension

Answer each question in one or two sentences. Use details from the story.

Chapter 1 · The Night of Masks

1. Why did Luca visit the Ferretti palace?

2. What did Luca say in front of the guests?

3. What strange thing did Luca see on a white mask?

4. Where was Luca when the cry came from upstairs?

Chapter 2 · A Man Accused

1. Which two items made Luca look suspicious?

2. Why was Marta afraid to give a clear answer?

3. What did Sofia promise Luca?

4. What important difference is there between anger and murder?

Chapter 3 · The Mask Maker's Mark

1. How did Luca mark the masks that he made?

2. What did Lorenzo say Giacomo planned to do?

3. Who bought green ribbon from Teresa?

4. Why did Elisabetta first refuse to help Sofia?

Chapter 4 · The Door by the Water

1. What did Marta remember about the kitchen bells?

2. What did Elisabetta promise Marta?

3. Why was the water door important?

4. How did Pietro react when Sofia asked about green ribbon?

Chapter 5 · The Price of Silence

1. What did Angelo say about the old warehouse?

2. What new fact did Luca remember about his cape?

3. What did Sofia find in her father's wooden box?

4. Why was Paolo afraid to tell the truth?

Chapter 6 · Two White Masks

1. What did Paolo really see near the water door?

2. What did Renzo remember about the bread and hammer?

3. What did Elisabetta learn from the business records?

4. Who asked a servant to buy green ribbon?

Chapter 7 · The Honest Account

1. Why did Sofia bring both records and witnesses to Rinaldi?

2. What happened when the lion-marked key was tested?

3. Why did Pietro say he was at the water door?

4. What did Sofia learn about proving the truth?

Chapter 8 · Before the Judges

1. Why was the first witness's identification weak?

2. How did Marta and Renzo help Luca?

3. Why did Elisabetta speak against her own family's interests?

4. What did the senior judge decide about Luca?

Chapter 9 · The Face Behind the Mask

1. Did the hearing immediately prove Pietro's guilt?

2. What did Elisabetta do when she visited the shop?

3. What new words did Sofia paint on the workshop sign?

4. What is the main lesson of the story?

Language Practice · A2

Work with the language of the story. Write your answers before checking the key.

Activity 1 · Past simple

1. Luca (carry) a box of masks to the palace.

2. Marta (drop) a wooden shelf in the kitchen.

3. Paolo (see) Pietro beside the water door.

4. The judges (ask) careful questions.

5. Sofia (find) the old bills at home.

6. Pietro (say) that he stayed in the hall.

Activity 2 · Choose the best connector

7. Luca was afraid, (because / but) Sofia came to help.

8. Sofia checked the accounts (before / although) the hearing.

9. Marta spoke slowly (because / while) she was frightened.

10. Pietro had a key, (so / although) he could open the chest.

11. The guests danced (while / because) Luca repaired the shelf.

12. Elisabetta was sad, (but / so) she chose to speak honestly.

Activity 3 · Vocabulary in context

Use each word once: witness · evidence · regret · honest · ribbon · accounts

13. A person who sees an event is a _____.

14. Sofia wanted strong _____, not rumors.

15. The mask had a green _____ inside.

16. Business money was written in the _____.

17. Giacomo began to _____ his old choices.

18. The shop promised _____ work and fair prices.

Activity 4 · True or false?

19. Luca made all thirty masks with green ribbon. T / F

20. Marta and Renzo remembered Luca in the kitchen. T / F

21. Paolo said that he saw Pietro kill Giacomo. T / F

22. Giacomo had decided to look into old business problems. T / F

23. The judges immediately gave Pietro a final punishment. T / F

24. Sofia believed that facts were stronger than rumors. T / F

Activity 5 · Put the events in order

Write the numbers 1–6 to show the correct order.

A. Sofia brings the new records to Rinaldi.

B. Luca delivers white masks to the palace.

C. Luca returns to the family workshop.

D. Marta agrees to explain her memory of the bells.

E. The merchant is found dead.

F. The judges review the witness statements.

Activity 6 · Give advice

Use should / should not to write one sentence for each person.

25. What should Marta do when she knows a fact?

_____

26. What should Luca do when he is angry about unpaid money?

_____

27. What should Pietro do if he has managed money dishonestly?

_____

28. What should the officials do before blaming a suspect?

_____

Activity 7 · Writing

1. Write 80–100 words as Sofia. Describe one day when you were afraid but decided to tell the truth.

2. Write 80–100 words as Elisabetta. Explain why you changed your mind about Luca.

3. Write a short newspaper report about the first hearing. Say what is known and what is still uncertain.

4. Write a different final conversation between Luca and Sofia, using at least four words from the glossary.

Activity 8 · Discussion

• Can someone be guilty of past mistakes but innocent of a new crime?

• Why are honest witnesses sometimes afraid to speak?

• What makes a piece of evidence reliable?

• Do you think Giacomo changed because of regret, fear, or both?

• What does the word “mask” mean at the end of the novel?

Answer Key

Reading comprehension — suggested answers

Chapter 1

1. Luca came to deliver masks and ask for unpaid wages.

2. He asked Giacomo to pay money promised to his family.

3. He noticed a green ribbon inside one of the masks.

4. He was helping Marta repair a kitchen shelf.

Chapter 2

1. His dark cape and a white mask from his workshop.

2. She feared Pietro might dismiss her and she needed her wages.

3. She promised to learn who wore the mask and find the truth.

4. Angry words do not prove that a person killed someone.

Chapter 3

1. He used two small grey stitches inside a mask.

2. Giacomo planned to examine old payments and make things right.

3. A young servant from Ferretti's house bought it.

4. She believed Luca had killed her father and was grieving.

Chapter 4

1. Luca was beside her with the hammer when the bells rang.

2. She promised to support Marta if she spoke honestly.

3. It gave someone another way to enter or leave the palace.

4. He avoided the question and tried to talk about other people.

Chapter 5

1. Repairs had not been done despite money being recorded.

2. Pietro had taken or borrowed Luca's cape.

3. Bills listing unpaid wages and work.

4. He feared losing his work and being punished by powerful people.

Chapter 6

1. He saw Pietro with a cape near the water door, not the murder itself.

2. He saw Luca in the kitchen during the bells.

3. The books showed worker payments were missing.

4. Pietro told the servant to buy it.

Chapter 7

1. She wanted the official to examine facts that fitted together.

2. It opened the second account chest.

3. He claimed he was visiting a friend, but the guards stopped him.

4. Several reliable facts matter more than one dramatic claim.

Chapter 8

1. The witness saw clothes and a mask, not Luca's face.

2. They described seeing him work in the kitchen during the bells.

3. She wanted to tell the truth despite the harm to her family's name.

4. The accusation against Luca was not supported well enough to keep him held.

Chapter 9

1. No. The investigation and further proceedings continued.

2. She paid Luca for the masks from her own household money.

3. MORETTI MASKS — HONEST WORK, HONEST PRICE.

4. Fair judgment needs evidence; we should listen honestly, even when truth is difficult.

Language Practice · Answers

Activity 1

1. carried · 2. dropped · 3. saw · 4. asked · 5. found · 6. said

Activity 2

7. but · 8. before · 9. because · 10. so · 11. while · 12. but

Activity 3

13. witness · 14. evidence · 15. ribbon · 16. accounts · 17. regret · 18. honest

Activity 4

19. False · 20. True · 21. False · 22. True · 23. False · 24. True

Activity 5

B=1 · E=2 · D=3 · A=4 · F=5 · C=6

Activity 6 · Example responses

25. Marta should tell the truth about what she remembers.

26. Luca should speak calmly and ask for help.

27. Pietro should admit his mistakes and return the money.

28. Officials should examine evidence before blaming someone.

Activities 7–8 have no single correct answers. Give clear reasons and support your ideas with details from the story.

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